Letting Loss Remain in the Darkness of the Old, and Letting Love Bloom in the Light of the New

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61748077.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Other She-ra Characters Mentioned but Not Present

Additional Tags:
Winter Solstice, SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), Family Fluff, Family Feels, Fluff, Domestic Fluff, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Holidays, Vacation, Solstice, Married Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Parenthood, catradora, Married Couple, Kid Fic, Baby Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Presents, Solstice traditions, Basically Catra and Adora Try to Give Finn the Childhood They Never Had, While Also Spoiling Each Other, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Catra and Finn are still Magicats Though, Winter Solstice is basically celebrated instead of Christmas in the Universe

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2024-12-29 Words: 9,712 Chapters: 1/1

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by AvatarBea

Summary

It's Finn's first Winter Solstice, and Adora and Catra try their very best to make it a great one.

Notes

Happy Solstice, AstrynSerene! I'm a huge fan of your series, "The Blonde Next Door." Although the story I've written for you doesn't take place in that universe, I tried to incorporate some elements from it that I've always been particularly fond of. I hope you enjoy what I've created and have a wonderful holiday season and new year!

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra was generally greeted the second she got home from work. With Finn now at the age where they can crawl, they were sure to rush towards the front door the second they heard a car pull into the driveway, eager for their Mama to pick them up and shower them with kisses. Adora was never too far behind the sixth month old, joining her family in an embrace and asking her wife how her day was.

So it was weird that no one met her in the entryway after the first workday of December.

She knew Adora and Finn were still home; her wife's Subaru was in the driveway and she could hear Finn's happy chirps coming from the living room. Curious, Catra decided to investigate, but didn't actually think there was anything to worry about. Adora probably just had to use the bathroom and put Finn in their playpen so they wouldn't get into trouble while she was away.

When the brunette actually did reach the living room, her confusion only grew. Finn was in a playpen just like she had suspected. It's not *their* playpen, though. This one is nothing like the one the couple had picked out during the final month of Adora's pregnancy, consisting of a simple mattress with walls made out of mesh. No, this one was much bigger, practically filling every inch of free floor space that existed between the couch and the tv. It was made mostly of plastic panels that could be added or taken away to change the size of the set-up. Some of those panels had different activities built into the design, including a sensory board and the tiniest slide Catra had ever seen. It's also… gingerbread themed? That's the best way she could describe it. The playpen was mostly a bright brown, but the top portions of the sides had been painted white to look like settled snow, and candy-like decorations covered the entire thing. There's even a little hideaway alcove built into one of the walls that looked exactly like a house someone would bake at Solstice Time.

"What in the world?" Catra muttered to herself.

Finn didn’t give Catra anymore time to ponder over the change in her house’s decor. They noticed she was home instantly and were beginning to let out impatient babbles to inform her of their demands to be held, arms held up expectantly.

“I’ve got you, buddy,” the mother assured, approaching the pen and reaching down to pick up her child. “Mama’s here.”

Finn began to purr, nestling their head into the crook of Catra’s neck as she mimicked their rumbling.

“Catra?”

The woman in question turned her body towards the nearby hallway, the smile on her face growing when she laid eyes on her wife. “Hey Adora.”

It looked like Adora had just gotten out of the shower, her hair still wet and skin glistening from the newly added moisturizer.

“Hey. Sorry I wasn’t able to meet you at the door. Have you been home for long?”

“Just a minute or so, and you don’t have to apologize.”

“I know, but I like seeing you the second you get here. We spend enough time apart as it is.”

A few years ago, that statement would’ve concerned Catra, causing her to wonder if she wasn’t doing her fair share to make Adora feel secure in their relationship. After lots of therapy and many long conversations, however, the brunette had come to better understand her wife’s meaning. While Adora frequently expressed a desire to spend a lot of time together, the blonde was trying to passive aggressively telling Catra that how she currently behaved wasn’t enough or expecting her to put other aspects of her life on hold. Growing up in the foster system had just made Adora feel like she didn’t have consistent access to love, affection, and belonging. She wanted to build a different life for her and the

family she had created with Catra, and to her that meant staying involved in each other's daily routines and activities.

"Well, I'll never say no to more time with my wife," Catra announced before she feverishly kissed Finn's forehead and added, "or with this little kitten."

"How was work?" Adora asked.

"Same as it is everyday. What about you?" Catra asked. Nodding her head toward the playpen, she said, "looks like you did some shopping."

"I got it on sale and factored it into the budget we're making for Finn's Solstice presents," Adora quickly stated, trying to justify the purchase. "I know it's not for a couple of weeks, but I figured they could get a lot of use out of it now. I know the theme is kind of winterish, but it'll be cute even in the summer, won't it?"

"I'm not mad, princess," Catra assured, grabbing her wife's hand and leading them over to the couch so they could more comfortably talk. Once sat, she placed their child in her lap and handed them a nearby toy to help keep them occupied. "We needed to get a bigger set-up for Finn now that they're crawling anyway, and I know that you wouldn't buy something that wasn't within our means. I'm just wondering if anything in particular made you feel the urge to buy it today, since you've never mentioned it before."

Adora took a deep breath. She had been preparing herself to have this conversation for the past few hours, hoping that if she worded everything in just the right way, she could get her wife on board with her plan for the holidays. "Finn and I went to Glimmer and Bow's place today."

Catra furrowed her brow in confusion. She had vaguely remembered seeing such a meeting written on their calendar, and it was fairly often that the trio met up. It provided an opportunity for Adora to get out of the house that wasn't running an errand.

She had no idea what it had to do with the topic at hand though. "Okay."

"It started off like it always did, us all eating lunch and the two of them playing with Finn. Then Glimmer started going on about how exciting it must be for us to get to celebrate their first Solstice, and it just stirred up a lot of feelings in me."

Catra watched as her wife stared intently at Finn, a wave of emotions obviously flowing through her. As much as the brunette wanted to press for further details, she knew she needed to wait for Adora to be ready to begin talking again.

After a few minutes of complete silence, Adora said, "I have no idea what I'm doing, Catra. I know every first-time parent feels that way, but for me it's true. I *really* have no idea what I'm doing."

"I don't really get what you're trying to say, babe."

When the blonde looked back up at Catra, tears were beginning to form in her eyes. "Neither of us really celebrated holidays growing up, especially the Solstice. Sure, we have our little tradition and started doing more things when we were adults, but I have no idea what the holidays look like through a child's eyes, or what activities are the most important to do."

"I don't think there's a universal standard for that, love. Every child has different interests and needs."

Adora nodded. "That's what Glimmer said, and that Finn won't even remember this year's celebration, so it's not like I'll be messing up their entire childhood if we take this year to just try and figure things out.

"It's what Bow said afterwards that impacted me the most, though. He reminded me that, in a way, this is my first Solstice too. I've never gotten to be a mom watching her kid play in the snow for the first time, or listening to their excited squeal as they open up a present they really want on Solstice morning. I can't go

back in time and get the childhood I deserved, but I can experience childlike joy in a different way, with you and Finn."

Despite her regular insistence that she was in no way soft, tears started to form in Catra's eyes. "That's a beautiful way to think about it."

"It got me thinking about what *I* want Finn's first Solstice to look like, and it all became so clear to me on the drive home. I want it to be a celebration of how important they are to us and how much they've grown in the short time they've been here. Then, when I was driving home and got caught at a stoplight, I saw a sign that the local baby store was having a sale. Before I knew it, I was taking Finn in with me and we were going down all the aisles, both of us excitedly pointing items out. When I saw the playpen, I knew we had to get it."

Adora's eyes shone brightly. "Just think of it, Catra. On Solstice morning, after all of the presents have been opened, Finn can take their new toys into the pen and zoom all around. It's big enough that we can even sit in there with them, showering them with kisses and helping them go down the slide."

"That sounds amazing," Catra instantly replied, the scene already so clear in her mind's eye. "I'd love for us to spend the holiday like that."

"Really?" Adora asked, beaming.

"Yes, really. Finn is for sure going to have a wonderful first Solstice."

"That wasn't the only idea I had," Adora excitedly announced, reaching over to grab her laptop from the side table where she'd left it.

Catra couldn't help but watch fondly as her wife opened up her device and began to hunt for the browser tab she needed for the moment. Adora's enthusiasm was practically radiating off her

body, evident in her bouncing left knee and the giddy looks she kept giving Catra and Finn.

Why this woman worries about her capabilities as a wife and mother I will never know, Catra thought to herself as she stroked her child's ears.

"Okay," Adora began once she found the page she had been looking for, moving so that both herself and her partner could see it, "what do you think of this cabin?"

Catra's eyes widened as she realized her wife had gone on a rental website. "Like, as in a place to celebrate the Solstice at?"

The blonde nodded. "It's perfect, actually; owned by this really sweet elderly couple. They're Magicats too, so the place is already set up to accommodate you and Finn; scratch-proof walls, floors, and furniture, and all the lights are on dimmers. And Marcy and Jonah- that's the couple's names- were so thrilled at the idea that a baby Magicat would be spending their first holiday in their cabin that they offered us a discount."

The brunette raised an eyebrow. "You already booked it?"

"Of course not. I wouldn't do that without talking to you first. I was just reaching out to see if those dates were even still available before I bothered bringing it up to you. They understood and have agreed to not book anyone else until tomorrow afternoon."

"What even are the dates you're proposing we stay there?"

"I was thinking we'd go up on the nineteenth and come back on the twenty-second. It would allow us to spend all of Solstice Eve and Day at the cabin, and you'd already have those days off of work."

"I don't care if I'd need to take off extra time at work; I'd do that for you and Finn in a heartbeat. I just want to make sure you've

thought this through. We wouldn't be able to spend any time with our friends like we normally do."

"Which I think honestly might be for the best. Remember how hectic Thanksgiving was?"

Catra winced at the memory. Going to three different meals at three different houses was a tradition for her and Adora, one that had gone back years. First, they'd have breakfast with all of their friends, then tag along with Glimmer and Bow to have lunch with their respective families, and finally having a nice quiet dinner with Adora's former foster sibling Mara and her wife Light Hope. While they had always cherished the memories associated with those meals, Finn's presence made their executions infinitely more complicated. It felt like Catra and Adora were running around with their heads cut off the entire day. They were constantly excusing themselves from the table to feed, change, or soothe Finn, who was overstimulated because of the constant changes in people and environments.

"I love the traditions we've participated in with our friends over the years, but they were honestly better-suited for us when we were childfree," Adora said. "I think it might be wise to spend the actual holidays just the three of us and see our friends on other days, in more relaxed settings."

Done with her proposal, Adora looked to her wife expectantly. "So? What do you think?"

Part of Catra wanted to insist they take more time to think about it. A trip to the mountains would be so different than anything they've ever done for the Solstice. Catra had tried to get Adora to go on similar vacations in the past, but her partner had always worried that doing so would send a statement to their friends that they weren't enough. Similar anxieties often lead to the blonde running herself ragged around the holidays, trying to make everything perfect for everyone but herself. What if this complete one-eighty made her feel worse instead of better?

“I don’t want you to regret doing this later down the line,” Catra softly admitted.

“I can understand why you’re worried about that, but I don’t think I could regret taking the time to be with you and Finn. When we got pregnant with them, I made a commitment to have joy in being a mother and not take the experience for granted. This will help honor that commitment.”

Well how was Catra supposed to say no after hearing that? With no hesitation left in her, she found herself saying, “book it.”

A proud grin on her face, Adora began to do just that.

It was the day before the three of them were set to leave for the cabin. The couple was ensuring everything was ready to go, dividing and conquering.

“Could you take Finn to the store with you?” Adora asked while Catra was putting on her shoes. “It’ll be a lot easier for me to pack if I don’t have to keep track of them.”

“Was already planning on doing it,” the brunette declared. “Anything you need that isn’t on the list?”

“Can’t think of anything. I’ll text you if that changes.”

“Great. I love you.”

“Love you too,” Adora replied, blowing a kiss to both her wife and child before heading in the direction of their bedroom.

Her attention now solely on Finn, Catra got her baby out of their high chair, placing them on her hip and cooing, “You wanna go out with Mama? You want to go grocery shopping?”

Finn let out a series of excited trills in reply.

“Then let’s go!” Catra exclaimed, grabbing her keys and heading for the front door.

Finn had a love-hate relationship with car rides. They hated the initial act of being strapped into the car, dramatically babbling and flailing their little limbs. They also didn’t like it when the car was stopped for long periods of time and their moms were too busy talking to each other to pay attention to them. The second the vehicle got into motion, however, they were completely content to look out the nearest window, their pupils dilated and their ears perked up in excitement.

It was a similar scenario with grocery carts. Catra and Adora had learned that it was best to not take Finn on trips to the store unless they were both there, one of them entertaining the baby while the other does the actual shopping. Catra wanted to allow Adora some time for herself before they went on vacation, however, and her plan was to get in and out quickly, only getting the items on the list. She hoped that would keep Finn’s dissatisfaction to a minimum.

Still, as an extra precaution, she brought along Finn’s favorite toy at the moment, a sensory toy in the shape of a fish. The second that her child was in the shopping cart, she clipped it to the handle bar so Finn wouldn’t constantly drop it on the ground.

“Here you go, buddy,” Catra began as she offered the baby their most prized possession. “Can you play with this while Mama gets the groceries?”

Finn latched onto the toy with glee, excitedly batting at it and reveling in the sounds the toy’s various textures produced.

The mother smiled and gave the six-month old an affectionate scratch behind their ear. “I’ll take that as a yes.”

As the brunette had expected, it wasn’t too hard for her to find everything on her list. Finn only needed to be calmed down a handful of times, and it usually only required Catra to give them a

few moments of her attention before they were once again content.

"You've been such a great helper, Finn," Catra praised as she began making her way to the front of the store. "Are you ready to go back home and see Mommy?"

Finn lit up at the mention of their other parent, happily gurgling.

"That's right; we're gonna go be with Mommy!"

Just before Catra arrived at the cash registers though, something stops her in her tracks.

With the Solstice only days away, she'd obviously already gotten all of Adora's presents. She'd gotten her wife a few practical things, but for the most part she tries to get the blonde fun and meaningful items.

Catra didn't know how she hadn't thought of getting Adora this one. She'd talked about wanting to start this tradition for years, always to Catra's chagrin.

An idea started to form in the brunette's head. She immediately began to go down the store's relevant aisles to see if she could make it happen, and a pleased grin formed across her face when she found that she indeed could.

Making her final selection out of the choices available to her, Catra held it out to Finn for an official stamp of approval. "What do you think? Would Mommy like this as a Solstice present?"

Catra knew her baby wasn't old enough to have an actual opinion about such things, but she decided to take their cheerful chirps as a yes anyway.

The pair checked out their items, Catra using the store's holiday services to wrap the part of Adora's gift that she would be opening on Solstice Eve. Once home, Catra carefully hid it behind the first aid kit Adora kept in the trunk of her SUV. This way it

would make the trip to the cabin with them without risking the surprise being ruined.

Just as the brunette had suspected, Adora began helping to unload the groceries the second Catra walked through the door. She was checking things off the packing list and sorting the items by what could be packed ahead of time and what needed to remain in the fridge overnight when she asked, "did you two have a good time?"

"Oh yeah," Catra said, sending a playful wink in Finn's direction, eliciting a happy giggle. "We had a blast."

Catra's never been all that excited about holidays, at least not to the extent that Adora was. This year, however, the Solstice can't come fast enough.

Catra is so grateful that Adora had made them do the drive up the day before Solstice Eve. The family wouldn't have actually been able to enjoy the day if they'd spent the majority of it in the car and then getting settled into the cabin. Rather than having to deal with all of that, the couple can cuddle for as long as they want. At least, until Finn begins to chirp loudly in the bassinet beside their bed.

With a chuckle, Catra picked the baby up and placed them in between her and her wife, where they began to playfully bat at her cheeks. "I think someone's eager to start the day."

"Of course they are," Adora replied, wrapping her arms around Finn and covering the top of their head in kisses. "They're excited to celebrate their first Solstice, and so am I."

Her wife smiles softly. "Me too."

Adora and Finn stayed in bed for a little longer to breastfeed while Catra got breakfast started and set up the living room. Using the cabin's smart tv, she signed into their streaming services and queued up *Frosty The Snowman* .

“All ready over here, babe,” Catra called out to her wife once she was done. “The rolls just need a couple more minutes in the oven to warm up too, so you guys can head to the table.”

Adora nodded, exiting the bedroom and settling them into their highchair at the small dining table that was just a few feet away from both the kitchen and the living room. The cabin was much smaller than their actual house. Only one person could be in the kitchen while remaining comfortable, and the place had only a bedroom with a single bathroom adjoining it. Still, its remote location in the mountains and rustic design made it the perfect place to celebrate the Solstice.

When the timer for the oven went off, Catra brought the tray of cinnamon rolls over to the table, along with a bowl of frosting, a carton of blueberries, and a jug of chocolate milk. The look and aroma of the assortment excited Finn, making them wiggle in their chair so much that it scooted across the floor a little.

“You can’t have the rolls or milk yet, buddy,” Adora tried to explain. “We’ll give you some smashed blueberries though.”

Finn narrowed their eyes at their mothers, giving them both a disapproving scowl when only the fruit was placed on the tray in front of them.

Catra couldn’t help but laugh. “They’re so sassy sometimes.”

“They get that from you,” the blonde teased playfully.

Catra smirked. “Darn right they do.”

Despite their displeased expression, Finn eventually began to eat the blueberries that had been set in front of them, their hands, face, and onesie soon stained its color.

“It’s a good thing we didn’t change them before breakfast,” Adora commented in between bites of her own food.

Catra hummed in agreement. “Learned that the hard way.”

When they were finished with their meal, Adora worked on putting the dishes away while Catra dressed herself and Finn.

Adora gasped when she saw her baby return in a dark green jumper. “They look so cute!”

“Don’t they always” the other mother asked. She had opted to wear black jeans and a loose red sweater.

“Well, yes, but they look especially cute today.”

“You’ve got me there. Now go get changed and meet us on the couch. Finn and I are eager to watch Frosty come to life.”

“I’m going, I’m going.” Before Adora went to the bedroom, she couldn’t stop herself from giving Finn’s foot a playful squeeze, eliciting their infectious giggles.

When Adora came back out into the cabin’s open area, now dressed in a long-sleeved white shirt and gray pants, her heart couldn’t help but lurch at the sight that was before her. Catra had made herself comfortable on the couch, her feet up on the ottoman and a blanket in her lap. Finn had decided that they too would get comfy, curling themselves into a ball on their mother’s chest and purring loudly.

Adora instinctively took her phone out of her pocket, snapping a picture of the precious moment.

Catra didn’t even have to look in her wife’s direction to know what she was doing, impatiently announcing, “We’re still waiting for you to join us.”

“You know I can’t help it,” the blonde insisted as she sat down next to her wife, relaxing into the arm that was instinctively put around her.

“I think you can help it, you just don’t want to.”

“Finn’s only gonna be this little for so long; I want to be able to look back on it whenever we want to.”

The brunette looked down at her child, noticing how their ear twitched as they picked up on their mothers’ conversation. “Me too. I also want us to be present in the moment though, so no phones during the movie, okay?”

Adora sat her phone face-side down on the coffee table. “Deal.”

The family stayed snuggled up throughout the film’s entire twenty-two minute runtime, Finn content to stay stationary due to the warmth from their mothers and their full tummy. Once the credits appeared and the screen was turned off, however, they started to wiggle out of Catra’s embrace. They were eager to find something else to keep them entertained, and they found it almost immediately. Just a few feet away from them was the new playpen that had brought them countless hours of fun over the past month, and they wanted to be inside of it so badly. Before their moms had a chance to even blink, they jumped down from the couch and darted over to the structure.

“Finn!” Catra shouted out of surprise rather than malice.

The six-month old just looked back at the couple expectantly, waiting to be placed inside the pen and have free reign.

Adora got up from the couch. “We were gonna play there next anyway. I’m just grateful they can’t jump over the sides.”

“Which is gonna start happening in about a month or two,” Catra warned.

Her wife sighed in exhaustion at the very thought. “All of this before they can even walk.”

“That’s what you get for having a baby with a Magicat.”

“I suppose so,” Adora said dramatically as she scooped Finn up and stepped into the playpen. Then, with a huge grin, she added,

“best decision I ever made.”

Catra’s heart swelled at that statement, compelling her to also get up from the couch and join her wife and child.

The three of them spent the next hour playing. They did everything from rolling balls on the floor for Finn to chase after to playing simple hand games like patty cake. Eventually Finn’s eyes began to grow heavy with tiredness, though they still became fussy every time Catra or Adora tried to carry them towards the bedroom for a nap.

“Looks like we might have to bring out the big guns,” Adora said as she walked over to the diaper bag.

Catra let out an exaggerated gasp for their baby, laying them down on the floor. “You know what that means, Finn? It’s story time!”

“Do you want to be in charge of reading or the stick puppets?” her wife asked.

“Reading obviously,” the brunette replied. “I’m much better at doing the voices then you are?”

“Of course. How silly of me to have thought otherwise,” Adora replied with a smile, sitting back down next to her wife and handing her the picture book she’d selected. Then she opened up a large ziploc bag and pulled out a bunch of animal pictures she’d printed out long ago and taped to popsicle sticks. “Ready whenever you are.”

Dramatically clearing her throat, Catra opened up the book and began to tell the story of a bear wandering through the forest and making friends along the way. She used a different voice for every character, each one more silly than the last. Every time she turned the page, Catra couldn’t help but pause for a moment to look over at her wife, who was waving around various popsicle sticks to try and set the scene for their child.

For the first half of the activity, Finn watched in awe. They hung onto their Mama's every word and their Mommy's every movement, giggling whenever something happened that they deemed hilarious. Eventually though, the call for sleep was too great, and the six-month-old began to keep their eyes shut for longer and longer periods of time, until they were out cold.

To ensure they were ready to stay asleep, Adora and Catra spent the extra minute or so finishing the story before starting to quietly pack up the materials.

"I could kiss you for putting together those story bags," Catra told her wife. Naptime had become so much easier ever since the blonde had read about story time in a blog post and started implementing it. The activity gave Finn a reason to be still long enough to put themselves to sleep, as opposed to Catra or Adora trying to fight them into listening to their body's cues.

"You have, on many occasions," Adora reminded with a smirk.

"And I will continue to do so for the rest of our lives," Catra proudly stated. She then carefully picked Finn up so she could transfer them to their bassinet in the bedroom. "What were you planning to work on while we're asleep?"

"Actually, I was thinking of napping with you guys," Adora announced.

Catra's ears perked up. On her days off, it was not uncommon for Catra to sleep whenever Finn was. She supposed it was a mixture of her maternal desire to be near her child and her Magicat affinity for napping throughout the day. Adora rarely did it though, arguing she needed to use the time of peace and quiet to check things off her to-do list. Catra tried not to press the issue, knowing incomplete tasks were a huge trigger for her wife's anxiety. Still, she couldn't deny that she felt lonely whenever her wife didn't join her in bed.

"Are you sure?" Catra asked, her voice hopeful.

The blonde shrugged. “I don’t really have anything I need to do, we’re on vacation, and it’s Solstice Eve. If there was ever a time to allow myself to rest, this would be it.”

“You never need a justification to rest, dummy,” Catra retorted. “I’m not about to look a gift horse in the mouth though. Let’s go to bed.”

Once Finn was placed in their bassinet, the adults slowly crawled into bed together. Adora automatically began spooning Catra, her arms wrapped around her as they closed their eyes.

Just before Adora drifted off to sleep, she softly whispered into her wife’s ear, “I think this is the best vacation I’ve ever been on.”

Catra purred loudly. “Me too.”

When they were kids, Catra and Adora had to adapt holiday traditions to work with life in the foster system. They never knew when they’d be forced to go to a new home or if they’d be allowed to bring more than a single duffel bag’s worth of stuff with them. That meant they had to be very selective about what objects they assigned value to.

It was very common for families to use their backyards to do a Solstice walk. They would use Evergreen branches and lit candles to create a spiral path, and everyone would walk along it while they reflected on what to leave in the past and what to embrace for the future. Catra and Adora didn’t have access to Evergreen branches, and were never allowed to have lit candles. No adult seemed to ever be invested enough in them to guide them through the walk either.

Catra had resigned herself to this fate, but Adora refused to do the same. When they were thirteen, the blonde had used what little money she had to buy two battery-operated candles from the local general store, insisting that every year, she and Catra would

turn them on the night before the Solstice started and keep them lit until the morning after it ended.

"Why do we need to keep them on the entire day?" Catra had asked.

"We need as much light as the universe will give us," Adora had responded.

"Why did you waste money buying two of them?" Catra had followed up. *"We share a room, dummy."*

"So if we ever get sent to separate homes we can both still do it," Adora had solemnly explained. *"Promise me you will."*

Catra had indeed promised, and she had kept that promise on the Solstices where she and Adora were forced to live apart. Now, however, she got to watch her wife turn on both of their candles and revel in the fact that she'll never have to keep it again.

"Let loss remain in the darkness of the old," Adora said once she had placed them on the windowsill of the cabin's bedroom. " Let love bloom in the light of the new."

"Where had you even heard that saying before?" Catra asked, holding Finn in her arms on the edge of the bed. "You've been reciting it since we were like sixteen."

Adora tilted her head in thought. "I can't remember. If I'm being honest, I probably saw it used in some cheesy Solstice advertisement for greeting cards or something. It's still a nice sentiment though, right?"

Catra simply hummed in agreement.

"Ready to do Finn's bedtime routine?"

"Before we do, the two of us have a little gift for you." The brunette went over to where they'd been keeping the presents,

grabbing one that was wrapped in a different color from all of the rest.

"We had agreed to open all of our stuff on the Solstice," Adora argued.

"I know, but I figured this one would be useful for you to have for tonight *and* tomorrow."

Curiosity overtaking her, Adora sat on the bed next to her wife before she took possession of the gift, beginning to unwrap it. Underneath the green paper was a folded up pair of ivory satin pajamas with a gingerbread cookie pattern added onto it.

"I figured I'd continue the theme you picked out for Finn's playpen," Catra stated.

"I love them," Adora announced as she held up the garment, impressed by its luxurious feel, "and you were right; I want to wear them tonight and throughout the day tomorrow."

"Then go ahead and get changed in them while I start getting Finn ready for bed."

"You don't mind?"

"Of course not. You do the hard work of feeding them, the least I can do is change their diaper and sing to them while you put on pajamas."

Smiling, Adora stood up. "I'll be right back, and then the two of us can finish sending them off to sleep before we relax in the living room."

"Sounds great."

Once the door to the bathroom was closed, Catra went through the steps of Finn's nightly routine. First, she gently massaged their limbs and stomach to promote healthy digestion and a good night's sleep. Next, she ensured they were clean, gently brushing

both their fur and the sharp baby teeth that were starting to come in. Once that was done, she placed the six-month old back in her arms and started to sing.

While she sang a traditional Magicat lullaby, her vision focused on the two LED candles sitting on the window frame. They were still glowing brightly even after all of these years, and Catra couldn't help but feel proud at that fact.

Everything was ready for tomorrow. All of the presents had been sorted and wrapped before the three of them had even arrived at the cabin, and their friends knew to let them have the morning to themselves before checking in via phone call or text messages. To top it all off, Catra had already set an early alarm on her phone. It would ring at a frequency too high for Adora's ears to pick up on, allowing the brunette to secretly carry out the second part of tonight's gift.

When she finished singing, Catra placed a gentle kiss on Finn's forehead before whispering, "we're gonna make sure Mommy has the best Solstice ever, aren't we?"

Finn dawned a sleepy smile and purred in response, secure in both their mother's arms and her love.

Adora had fully expected to wake up Solstice morning the same way she had the day before, with her wife's arms wrapped around her and her baby trilling for her attention. Instead, she found herself completely alone, the only sign of the others' presence in the bedroom last night being disturbed sheets and a note on Catra's pillow that read *'Finn and I wanted to let you sleep in for once. Come join us whenever you're ready.'*

Reaching for her phone, Adora soon realized that it was a little after ten thirty; Finn would've already been done with their first nap of the day. The blonde smiled at the kind gesture, but she had no intentions of staying in bed any longer. This was Finn's first Solstice, and she didn't want to miss a second of it.

After a quick trip to the bathroom, Adora walked down the hallway and toward the living room.

Her heart almost stopped when she took in the sight before her.

Catra was helping Finn use the slide built into their playpen, holding their tiny hands as they went down before quickly placing them back at the top. If Catra's coos of encouragement and Finn's squeals of delight were anything to go by, the duo was having a blast.

That wasn't the main thing to get Adora's attention, however; Catra and Finn had also changed into the same pajamas that the blonde had been given the night before.

Catra then noticed that her wife was standing a few feet away. A wide smile appeared on her face as she placed Finn on her hip and said, "Finn's been changed and had a bottle, and I've already eaten. I made you a plate of cinnamon rolls that you just need to heat up in the microwave. Don't worry, we haven't opened any presents; the holiday was never going to start without you."

"You got us all matching pajamas," was all Adora said in reply.

"Yes, I did. I had the store wrap up your pair and hid mine and Finn's in the trunk of your car. Surprise!"

"You've always said that matching outfits were way too cheesy."

"I still stand by that, but maybe I could stand to be a little bit more cheesy. With this being Finn's first Solstice, it's the perfect time to start new traditions."

Catra turned her eyes towards Finn, absentmindedly stroking the hair on their head as she continued to speak. "I've been thinking a lot about what you said the day you suggested we take this vacation, about how what's most important for the holidays is doing the stuff that we want. As much as I sometimes hate to admit it, I do want Finn to have those picture-perfect holiday memories, the ones I couldn't give either of us growing up. I want

them to wish for the most frivolous things instead of basic necessities. I want them to make a huge mess in the living room from opening up presents and not caring where the wrapping paper landed, without worrying for a second they'll get in trouble for it. I want them to fall asleep in our arms on Solstice night and know that they can count on us to be with them next year and every day in between, because we're their moms and we love them so much."

Adora's eyes were already filling with tears at her wife's confession before the brunette continued, "I have wants for you too, Adora. I want you to feel totally free to celebrate the holidays, knowing that they're important to me because they're important to you. I want you to feel pride in the family you've created and know how much Finn and I value the things you do for us. I want you to feel cherished and *loved."*

Adora couldn't take it anymore. She closed the gap between her and Catra, mindful of the baby that is still on her wife's hip. The blonde kissed her in a way that was passionate and tender all at the same time.

When they had to pull away for air, Adora whispered, "I do. I feel cherished and loved by you and Finn, today and everyday."

Catra smiled softly. "That's the only Solstice gift I'll ever need."

"That may be, but there's no way that's all you're getting," the blonde insisted. "Finn and I have been planning this day for months now."

"Oh really? You guys have been conspiring behind my back?"

"You say that as if the two of you didn't abandon me in bed and surprise me with an entire wardrobe change."

Catra rolled her eyes at her wife's dramatic choice of words. "We did not *abandon* you in bed."

“I was deprived of my morning cuddles, Catra! Believe me, you will be making up for that during nap time!”

Catra chuckled. “Alright, I can agree to that. How about, for now though, we get you something to eat?”

“I’m not that hungry,” Adora tried to argue. “I’d rather just start opening presents.”

“Not until you’ve taken care of yourself, princess.”

“What if I eat while Finn opens their first few gifts?” Adora offered in compromise.

Knowing that was as good of a deal as she was going to get, Catra nodded. “Want to warm up your plate while I get them from the bedroom?”

“Yes please,” Adora said, already making her way to the kitchen.

Less than five minutes later, the family had reconvened on the living room couch. Adora was stuffing her face with cinnamon rolls, Catra was opening the three big bags of presents she had just brought over, and Finn was in between the two, happily playing with their sensory toy.

“I already know that everything in red wrapping paper is for Finn and everything in gold’s for you, so I’m assuming what’s black is for me?”

Adora nodded, swallowing her food before adding, “just like with Finn, your smaller presents are on top too.”

“That’s how I put your bag together as well. How do you want to do this? Just let Finn open all of their presents before we open ours?”

“I think they’d get overstimulated really fast that way. How about we let them open a couple at a time before they take a break and

play with whatever they've gotten so far. That'll be when we open our gifts."

"Works for me."

Catra reached into Finn's bag and pulled out their first present, offering the small box to her child. "Here you go, baby. Happy Solstice."

Finn's focus on the toy in their hand went completely out the window once their mother had presented them with something new and shiny. They grabbed the object with a surprising amount of strength, pulling it towards them and running their hands along its sides for inspection.

"Want us to help you open it?" Adora asked softly as she used her fingers to peel away a small portion of the wrapping paper.

The six-month old eyes went big as saucers at that action, quickly catching on and using their tiny claws to start ferociously tearing away at the present's outer shell.

Catra laughed. "They might end up liking doing this more than the actual present itself."

"Fine by me," Adora announced.

Once the box was completely unwrapped, Finn's parents helped them open it up, revealing a set of dinosaur-shaped teething rings.

"This might not be the most exciting gift, baby," Adora started as she scratched behind her little one's ear to make them purr, "but your mom and I are gonna really appreciate it. You're already starting to get quite the set of choppers on you."

"Yep," Catra agreed with a smug smile that showed off her fangs, "already taking after your Mama."

Finn was handed a slightly larger present to open next. From the way it was so carefully wrapped, Catra could tell that Adora had picked out this one. While the two of them had gotten together to decide on most of Finn's gifts, they'd also set a budget for each of them to do their own personal shopping if they felt so inclined.

When the present was revealed to be a set of rollable plush safari toys, Catra couldn't hold back a small laugh.

"What?" Adora asked, a blush forming across her face. "Did I pick out a bad gift?"

Catra just shook her head, pulling out the next item and quickly helping her child unwrap it to show she had gotten Finn the exact same thing.

Adora had no choice but to laugh too. "Great minds think alike, I suppose."

"Well, if there was any present to get a duplicate of, this would be the one. Heaven knows they're gonna keep batting them underneath the couch."

After Finn had opened two more gifts, which had turned out to be a rattle and crinkle mat, their mother's decided it was a good time to stop for a break and open some of their own presents. They sat the six-month old on the floor and handed them one of the rollable plushies, which Finn was all too eager to pass between each of their hands and crawl after whenever it got away from them.

"Here," Adora said as she gave her wife two presents, "Open these first; they're from both me and Finn."

Catra grabbed them with her left hand and used the right to pass two of her own gifts to the blonde. "So are mine, and I'm not going until you go."

Adora rolled her eyes, but any annoyance she had melted away when she opened up the first present and saw that it was a tan

sweatshirt that had ‘ *Mom* ’ embroidered on the front with Finn’s name and birthdate on the right sleeve.

“I saw you looking at the Etsy listing a couple months ago,” Catra revealed. “I figured you’d never actually buy it for yourself, so I might as well do it for you.”

“I love it.” Adora declared.

“I think you’re gonna like the next present even more,” her wife said, motioning towards the smaller gift still sitting in her wife’s lap.

Taking the hint, Adora began to unwrap the second item, revealing a wooden box with a homemade clay ornament inside. On the front was an upside down impression of Finn’s footprint that had been painted to look like the base of a snowman, and on the back were the words *‘Finn’s First Solstice.’*

“Oh Catra,” Adora started as she held up the object to get a better look at it. “This is beautiful.”

Catra smiled. “You always comment on how cute Finn’s feet are. Figured we had to immortalize them.”

“Seems like we yet again had similar thoughts in picking out gifts.”

The brunette tilted her head. “What do you mean?”

“Open the small gift,” Adora encouraged.

Catra obeyed, ripping open the wrapping paper to find a jewelry box. Inside was a gold necklace with an engraved pendant that had two fingerprints overlapping in the shape of a heart.

“The one on the right is mine and the one on the left is Finn’s,” the blonde explained. “The company obviously had to enlarge theirs so it would fit the design, but that’s the only modification that was made. I wanted you to be able to have a reminder of us whenever you felt like it.”

Catra immediately put the necklace on, beaming. “I’ll cherish it always.”

The other present turned out to be a gift certificate for a Magicat-friendly bakery that Catra would sometimes take Finn to on her days off.

“I know you’re gonna love using this, buddy,” Catra called out to her child, who was starting to lose interest in the plushies. Once they looked in the direction of their Mama’s voice and noticed that their parents had gotten new items in their hands and laps, they abandoned their spot on the floor and crawled over to the couch at lightning speed.

Adora giggled at their baby’s excitement. “Good thing we’ve got more gifts for you to open.”

The family took turns opening presents three more times. Finn got new outfits and a few more toys. Catra got a pair of barefoot shoes, a headset that was custom made for her ears, and a new bag for work. Adora got things to add to her home work-out station, a horse-themed mug, and an array of new tea blends she was already eager to try.

It was finally time for the big presents. Catra and Adora had decided that they didn’t need to get anything extravagant for Finn this year. They were more likely to play with the box it came in than the object itself. Besides, this way the remaining money allotted for gifts could be put towards getting them things throughout the year as they grew and changed interests. Both women had insisted on getting each other a main gift, however.

“I want you to open your present first,” Catra announced, handing Adora a fancy white box with a golden bow tied around it.

“Of course you do,” Adora replied. “You're so competitive.”

Catra snorted. “Like you aren’t.”

Deciding not to take the bait, Adora opened the box, confusion taking over her when she saw that it was a custom-ordered book with a picture of her and Finn on it.

Catra quickly began speaking, not wanting her wife to get the wrong idea. "I know you have your own personal scrapbook for Finn and their milestones. I'd never want to take that from you, but I also thought it'd be good for you to have one that was made for you and is more focused on your journey as a mother."

Silently, Adora opened the book. After the introduction, the first page was mostly filled by a picture of her holding up a positive pregnancy test, a blinding smile on her face and eyes glistening as she looked at the camera. The writing underneath the photo said *'it's official; we're having a baby!'*

The next few pages highlighted Adora throughout her pregnancy. Unlike with Finn's baby book though, there were no ultrasound pictures or mentions of what size Finn would've been around that time. Instead, it was all about Adora and what she had been going through during that time; her cravings, what cute baby fact she was currently obsessed over, and how she would never miss an opportunity to tell the people around her how excited she was to be a mom.

When the timeline reached Adora's labor and delivery, Adora couldn't help but notice the photos now included added commentary from Catra. She found herself stopped on a particular image for quite a while. The blonde was in a hospital gown, standing up but putting all of her support on Catra, wrapped tightly in her arms. The Magicat seemed to be gently swaying the two of them back and forth as her wife was battling a contraction. Catra had written in the margins, *'this is one of my favorite pictures from that day, and I'll forever be grateful for the trust you put in me to help take care of you.'*

"Catra," Adora started, trying to find a way to express the emotions that were flooding through her.

“Before you say anything, there’s one more thing I want to show you.” Catra leaned over and turned the book a few pages. “I had all of our friends write their favorite memory they have of you being a mom.”

Sure enough, the blonde was presented with a paragraph from Bow, recounting when Adora had first introduced him and Glimmer to Finn from her hospital bed. He described how the joy she emitted was nothing short of contagious and that, as much as he loved meeting Finn, seeing his best friend safe and so happy was what had truly made the moment special. Alongside his account was a picture he had apparently taken from that day in secret, in which Adora was talking to Glimmer animatedly while holding a sleeping Finn in her arms.

Adora was full on crying now, unable to contain just how touched she was at this gesture from her wife. Unfortunately, Finn saw the tears from their mother and mistook them for a display of pain, causing them to start to whimper.

Catra was quick to act, taking Finn into her arms and holding them close to her chest. “It’s okay, Finn. Mommy wasn’t crying because she was sad.” She then looked to her wife and asked, “you weren’t, right?”

“No,” Adora affirmed, her voice a little shaky, “I wasn’t. I just love you so much, Catra.”

The brunette smiled softly. “I love you so much too, Adora. You’re an amazing wife and mother. You’re an amazing person in general, and I want to do whatever it takes to help you see that.”

Adora decided not to respond with words, instead wrapping her arms around her wife and child, holding them as close to her as she physically could.

Eventually, once Adora was sure she wouldn’t shed any more tears and upset Finn, she pulled back and said, “now my gift seems really dumb.”

“I know for a fact that it isn’t,” Catra said. “I’ll love whatever you got me.”

“Are you sure? I can just get rid of it.”

“And leave me with one less gift? No thank you.”

Adora smiled at her wife’s words and decided she should at least let her wife see what the present was before she took any further action. Reaching into the bag she had placed all of Catra’s gifts into, she pulled out a simple white envelope and handed it over to the brunette. “I couldn’t actually bring the gift with us, so I figured this would have to do.”

Her curiosity piqued, Catra tore open the envelope and pulled out two pieces of paper. The first was a confirmation email for a delivery and installation date, and the second was a printed out picture of a circular hammock chair.

Adora smiled shyly. “I know how much you’ve always wanted one, so it’ll be in our bedroom by the end of the year.”

Catra’s eyes went so wide in excitement they were basically black. “You’re getting me my very own swing?”

Adora laughed. “Basically, yes. It’s one that’s big enough for you to curl up and nap in, and it’s gonna go by the window so you can sunbathe too.”

“Adora, how could you possibly think this gift is dumb!? This is gonna be awesome!”

“It will?”

“Yes! I can sit up high while I rock Finn to sleep, or the two of us can look out the window and point out all of the sights and sounds to each other. We’re gonna love that!”

Finn, who was picking up on their mother’s excited tone, let out a series of happy babbles.

“See, Finn agrees with me! Thank you, Adora.”

The blonde smiled, her heart bursting with pride. “You’re welcome, love. I hope I was able to give you a great Solstice.”

“Your presence alone would’ve made this a great Solstice, but everything else you’ve done has been amazing too.”

“I feel exactly the same way.”

Overwhelmed by the love she had for her wife, it became Catra’s turn to pull her wife into a swift embrace. This day had filled her with so much happiness, and it was just getting started.

It was right after their early dinner that it started to snow. The couple didn’t even need to say a word to each other, automatically bundling themselves and Finn up in warm clothes and heading out to the yard.

For a while they just stood out in the open, allowing the gentle snowfall to wash over them. Finn’s eyes remained wide in wonder the entire time, enthusiastically grabbing at the snowflakes and giggling.

When the sun set, the couple situated themselves on the cabin’s covered front porch swing, Finn’s face buried into the crook of Catra’s neck. It wouldn’t be too long before it was time to put them to bed, after which she and Adora had plans to cuddle up on the living room couch and watch classic holiday movies together.

Adora moved impossibly closer to her wife, wrapping an arm around her. “So, what’s the verdict? Do you think this was a good way to celebrate Finn’s first Solstice?”

Catra softly smiled before saying, “I don’t think, Adora. I *know.* I’ll forever be grateful for you putting this together for us.”

The blonde blushed. “I just found the cabin. The rest we did as a team.”

Catra gently shook her head. “You knew exactly what the three of us needed to enjoy the day as a family.”

Adora beamed at the praise but said nothing in reply, content to enjoy the time with her family.

After a few minutes, Catra started, “When we get back home-”

Adora interrupted her wife with a groan. “Don’t you dare remind me that our vacation is ending tomorrow. Let me live tonight in ignorant bliss, please.”

“When we get back home,” Catra repeated in a tone that was somehow both gentle and firm, “we should reach out to Marcy and Jonah.”

“Of course. We need to thank them for letting us use the cabin at a discounted rate.”

“That, and to see when is the earliest we can rent it for next year’s Solstice.”

The blonde’s eyes went wide in excited surprise. “Really?”

Her wife nodded. “There aren’t that many Magicat-friendly places that would provide us with the privacy and view of this one. I think coming here should be a part of our Solstice traditions from now on.”

Adora’s smile grew impossibly wider, her mind filled with visions of her family cuddling on this very swing year after year. “That sounds perfect. I love you, Catra.”

“I love you too.”

The two shared a kiss, wrapped their arms around their baby, and blissfully watched the snow continue to fall.

End Notes

I'm so grateful to the SPOP flex group for making this event, it reminded me why I love writing so much. To anybody who reads my other stuff and have noticed I haven't been active since May, I'm sorry. It's been a tough year for me (maybe I'll use some of my experiences as a basis for a fic one day lol), but I want you to know I'm still committed to writing, especially family fluff!

As always, thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!